

Assignment 4

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Vital Sign Description: Glasgow Coma Scale

Developed in 1974, the Glasgow Coma Scale (GCS) is a measure of how conscious a patient is. It determines if a patient meets the medical definition of consciousness: being awake, alert and exhibiting understanding of oneself/their surroundings. The three responses tested are eye, motor and verbal. The eye response is worth four (4) points and tests how awake a patient is and if the body responds to stimuli. The verbal response, worth five (5) points, categorizes awareness and overall mental faculties. Finally, the motor response examines neuromuscular function; it is worth six (6) points.

GCS scores range from three (3) to fifteen (15). Significant GCS scores include 3 which indicates that the patient is entirely unresponsive while 15 indicates that the patient is alert and oriented. A score of 8 is typically the threshold at which intubation of the patient is considered. The GCS can be used to ascertain the condition of a patient's mental faculties after conditions such as traumatic brain injuries, concussions, low blood sugar or seizures. The GCS has proven to be a valuable diagnostic tool for categorizing and tracking patient brain function over time. This is essential for triaging by allowing medical professionals to categorize patient urgency and allocate resources accordingly, thus providing immediate life-saving interventions to the urgently ill. Furthermore, when its use is augmented by other health indicators, such as mean arterial pressure (MAP), it becomes even more potent.

References

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